



Achieving Behaviour Change Through Communications

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Aim of this presentation

To explore:

- how to use the COM-B model and Behaviour Change Wheel to develop an effective communications strategy
- how to turn the strategy into a campaign that has the desired impact, and the potential of Generative AI to help

Outline

- Communication and its role in behaviour change
- Developing a communication strategy using behavioural science
- Turning the communication strategy into a campaign

Communication and its role in behaviour change

The role of communications in behaviour change

Intervention functions

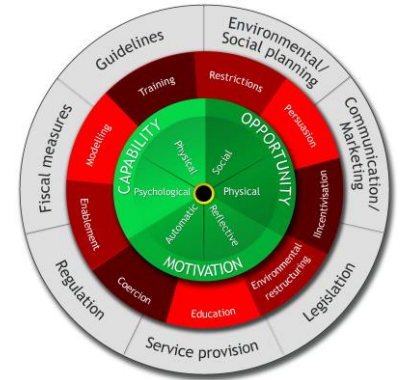
Educate
Persuade
Incentivise
Coerce
Train
Restrict
Restructure
Model
Enable

Policy options

Communications

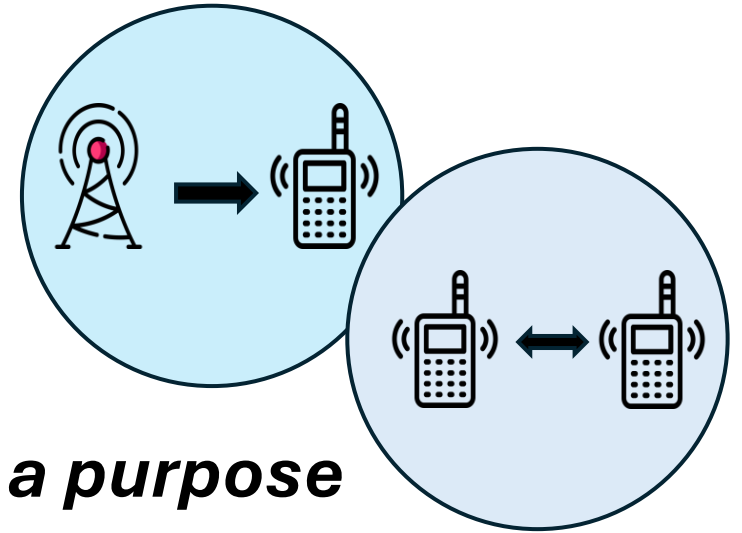
Guidelines
Env'l and social planning
Legislation
Service provision
Regulation
Fiscal measures

Behaviour



What is communication?

- Transmission of information
- ‘Active communication’ is communication ***with a purpose***
- It involves a source, a message and a receiver

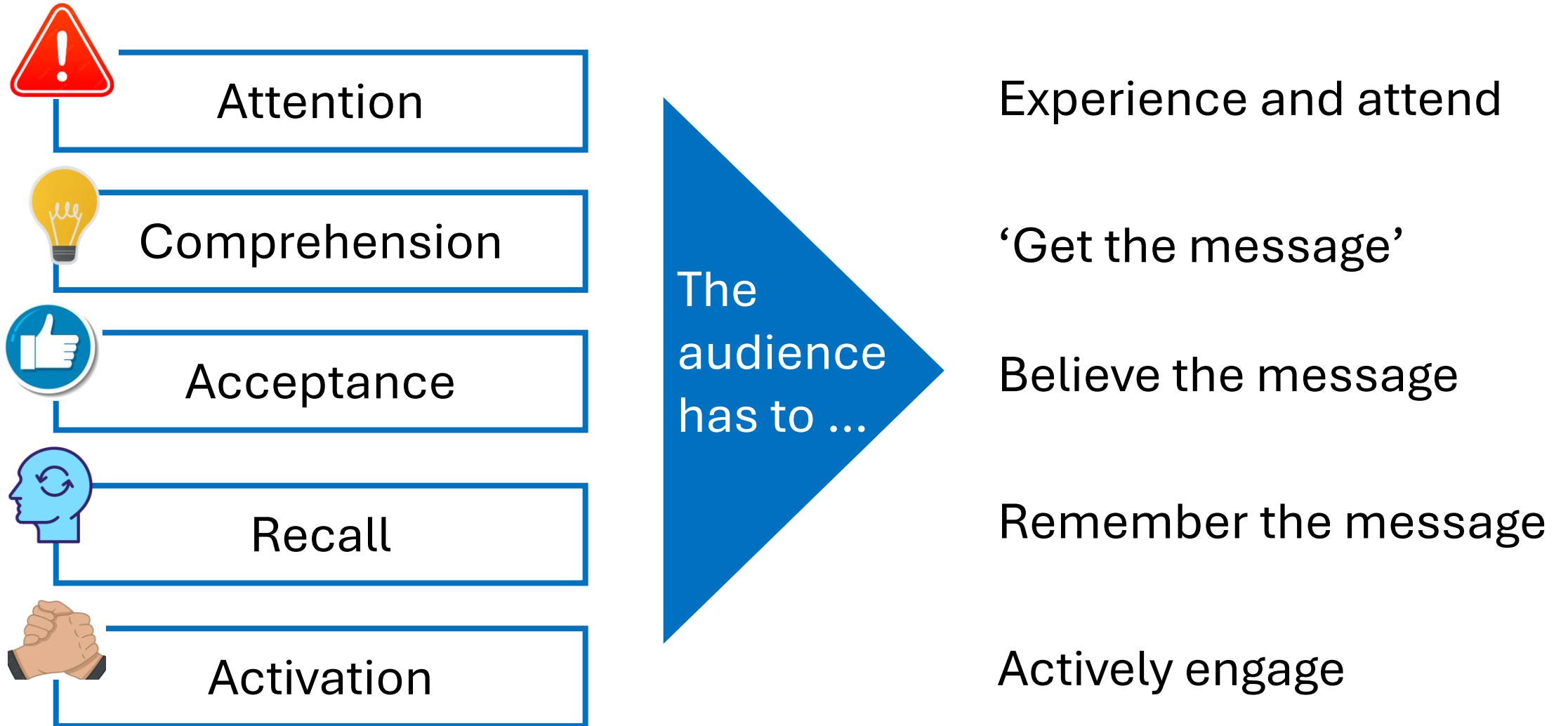


Active communication is successful to the extent that its purpose is achieved

Mortensen, C. David, ed. *Communication theory*.
Routledge, 2017.

Berger, Charles R., Michael E. Roloff, and David R.
Ewoldsen, eds. *The handbook of communication science*.
Sage, 2010.

Active communication pre-requisites



Types of communication function

Informative

- Apprise
- Show
- Remind
- Explain
- Promise
- Confirm
- Threaten
- Warn

Injunctive

- Permit
- Suggest
- Recommend
- Invite
- Request
- Plead
- Exhort
- Command

Emotive

- Associate
- Support
- Inspire
- Reassure
- Validate
- Celebrate
- Challenge
- Joke
- Empathise
- Comfort

Inquisitive

- Check
- Enquire
- Ask
- Probe
- Demand

Types of communication tone

Warm

Generous
Friendly
Playful
Rebellious
Empathetic
Whimsical
Ironic

Cool

Commanding
Stern
Dramatic
Urgent
Mysterious
Heroic
Technical

Types of audience

Friendly	vs	Hostile
Attentive	vs	Distracted
Receptive	vs	Sceptical
Knowledgeable	vs	Uninformed
Active	vs	Passive
In-sync	vs	Out-of-sync
Diverse	vs	Homogeneous

Audience out of sync?



Address your audience's preconceptions



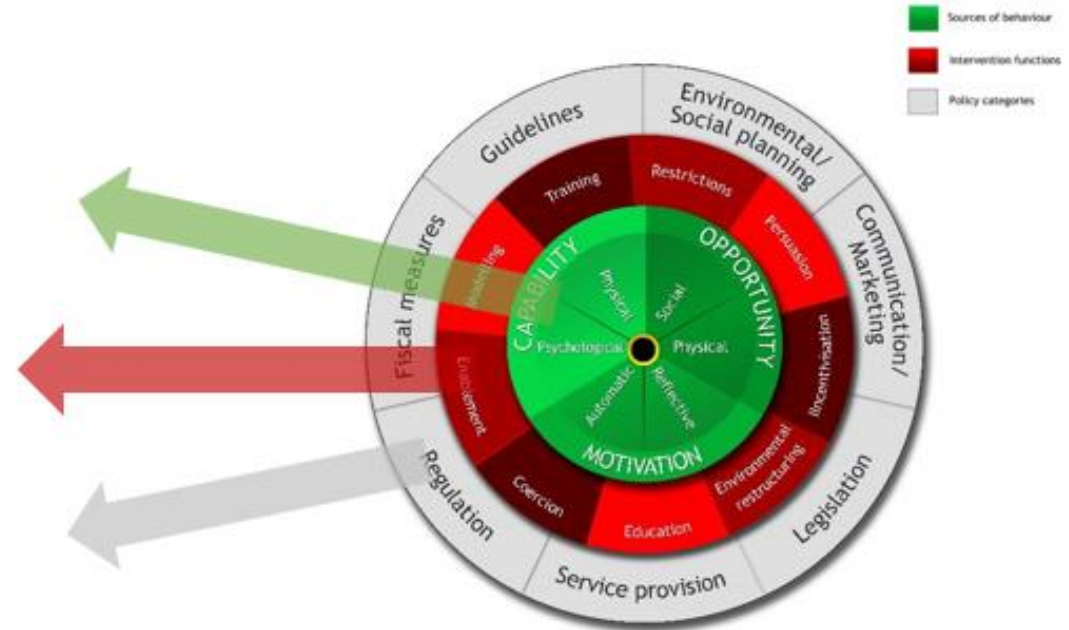
Key messages

Communicate to activate

- Every behaviour change intervention should include a communications strategy
- With active communication the audience must: attend, comprehend, accept, recall and engage
- The source and message must be tuned to the receiver
- Important features to consider are the communication function, tone and audience

Developing a communication strategy

A standard framework for intervention development



The COM-B model and
Behaviour Change Wheel

Details can be found in Public Health Wales Guide



<https://phwwhocc.co.uk/bsu/wp-content/uploads/sites/6/2023/03/PHW-BSU-Guide-1.pdf>

And the Behaviour Change Wheel book



<https://silverbackpublishing.org/products/behaviour-change-wheel>



<https://phwwhocc.co.uk/wp-content/uploads/2023/03/BSU-Comms-Guide-Eng-v0e.pdf>

For more information about
Public Health Wales
Behavioural Science Unit



Uned Gwyddor Ymddygiad
Behavioural Science Unit



<https://phwwhocc.co.uk/bsu>

For power users of COM-B and the BCW ...



A spreadsheet-based tool
to structure the process
of identifying relevant
BCTs



<http://bit.ly/42osKJ6>

BCW process adapted for communications



COM-B diagnosis: Capability

- How aware are they of the behaviour and precisely what constitutes it?
- How well do they know how to do it?
- How well do they understand the benefits of doing it or costs of not doing it?
- How confident are they that they can do it?

COM-B diagnosis: Opportunity

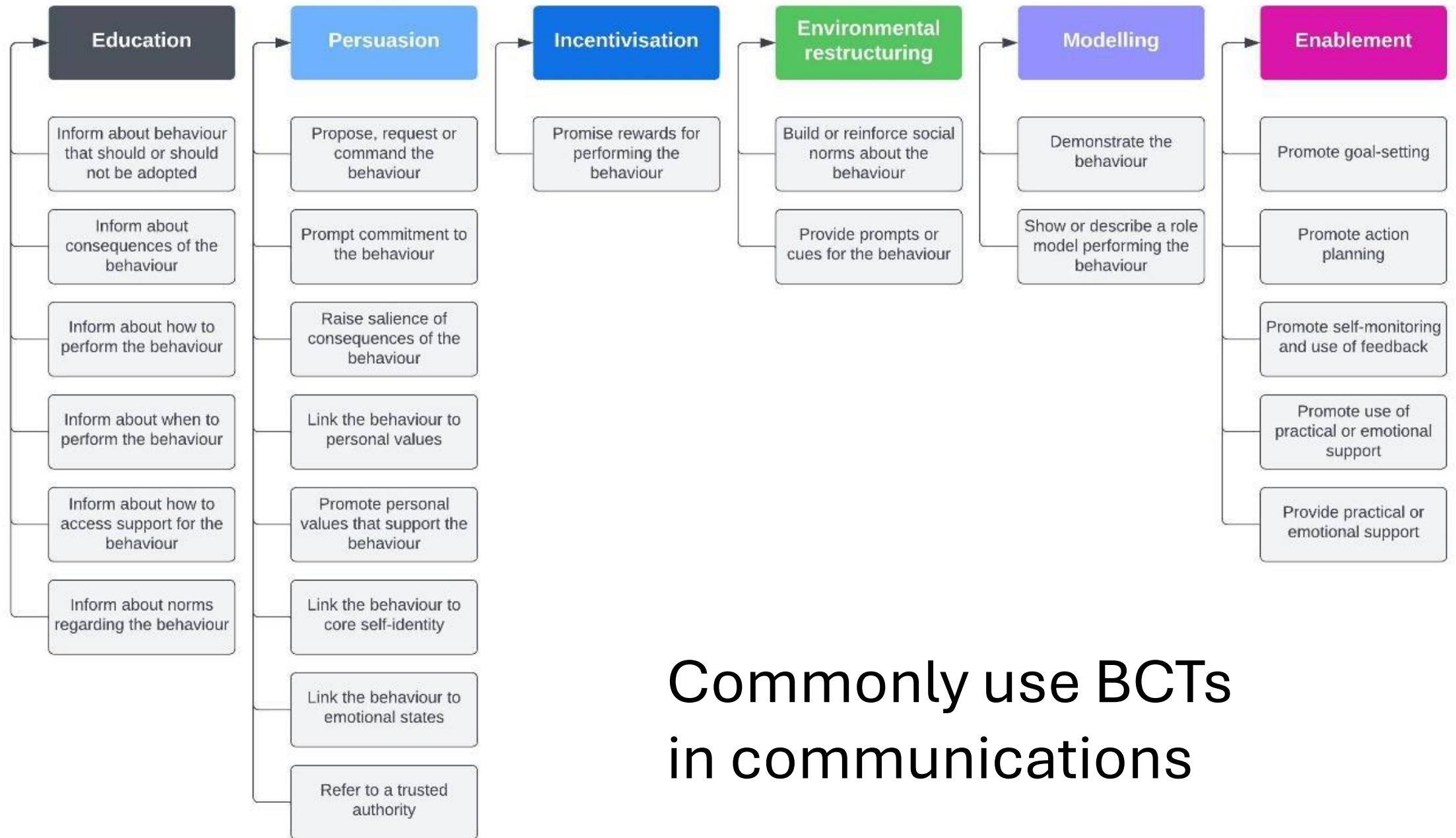
- How far is it considered 'normal' within their social environment?
- How far are there rules or expectations about the behaviour?
- How much support do they have in their social environment to do it?
- How far are they exposed to prompts, cues or reminders to do it?

COM-B diagnosis: Motivation

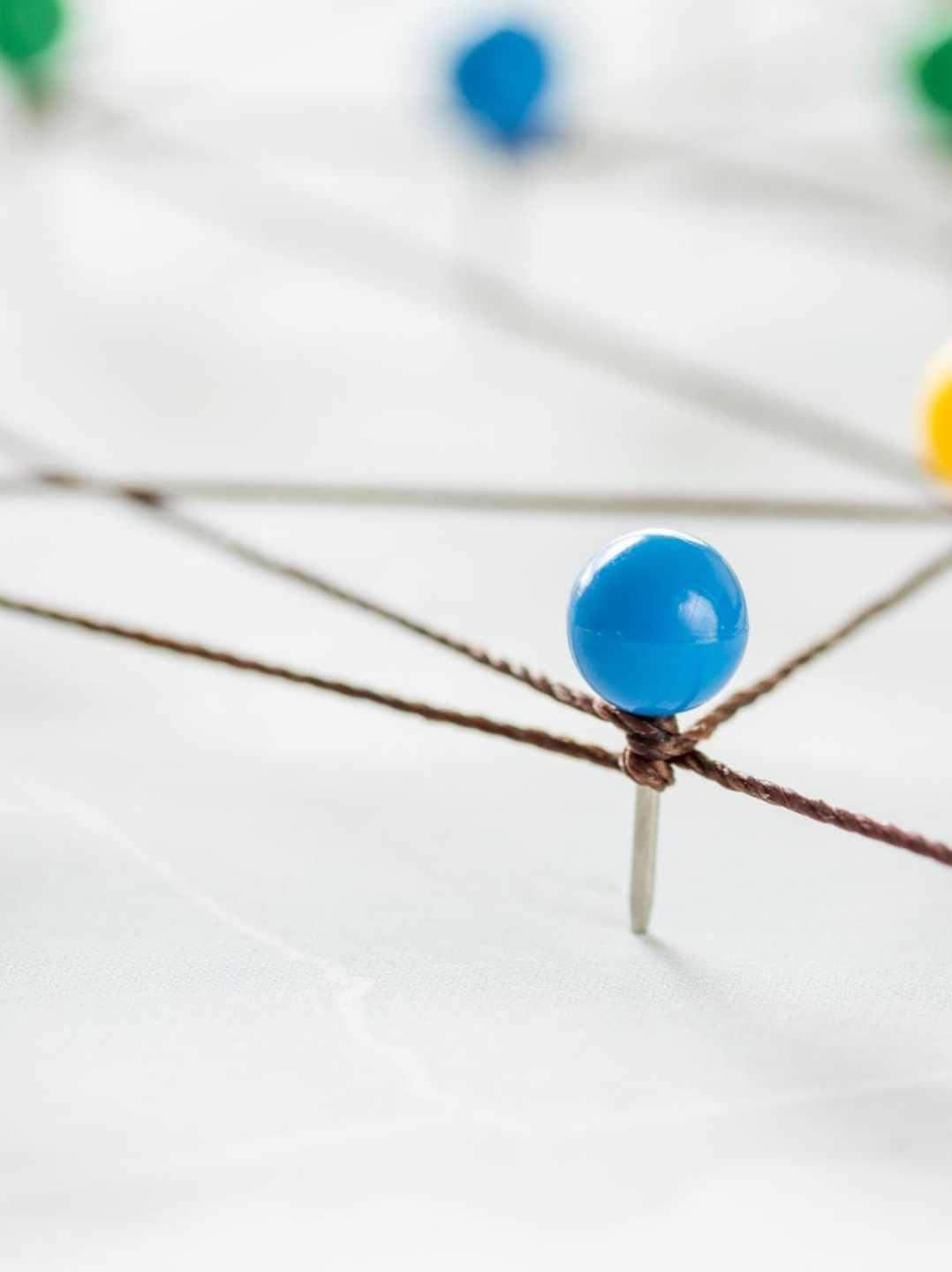
- How worthwhile do they think it is?
- How much enjoyment or satisfaction do they expect to get from it?
- How far is it provoked by an emotion or a drive state?
- How far do they expect it to reduce or prevent mental or physical discomfort?
- How well does it fit with their self-identity?
- How strong is their intention to do it?
- How strong a priority is it for them over other things they could be doing?

COM-B Targets to ‘Think Feel Act’ targets

COM-B target	Think-Feel-Act Target
Raising awareness/salience	Think: A mindset conducive to the behaviour Feel: A feeling of importance around the behaviour
Increasing understanding	Think: Knowing how to perform the behaviour Think: Knowing why the behaviour is important
Promoting social norm	Think: Believing that the behaviour is normal Act: A social environment that demands the behaviour
Providing prompts	Act: A physical and social environment that triggers the behaviour
Increasing attractiveness	Think: A belief that the behaviour is worthwhile and a priority Feel: A feeling of desire to perform the behaviour
Promoting habit	Act: Behaviour that occurs without thinking



Commonly use BCTs
in communications



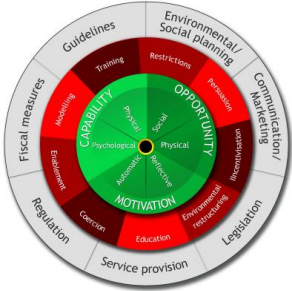
Key messages

Map the path to impact

- Chart a clear causal path from what needs to change to what content and delivery are best suited to achieving this in the target audience
- Do a COM-B diagnosis to decide what to target and then use formal process to select behaviour change techniques based on evidence and theory

Turning the communication strategy into a
campaign

Achieving campaign objectives



Behaviour Change
Techniques to
target COM-B
diagnosis



Attention



Comprehension



Acceptance



Recall



Activation



IMPACT

Communication strategy

BCTs

Implementation



Communication campaign

Message

Source

Delivery

Campaign design choices

Message

BCT

Function

Tone

Audience focus

Source

Type of source

Consistency

Authority

Delivery

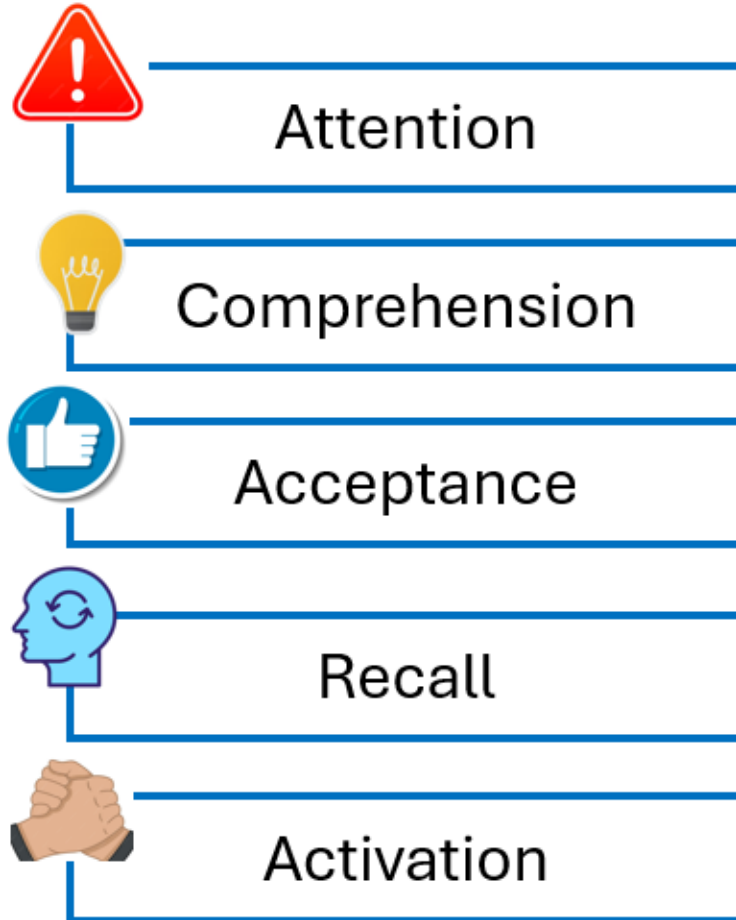
Channel

Schedule

Design

Mode

Promoting message impact



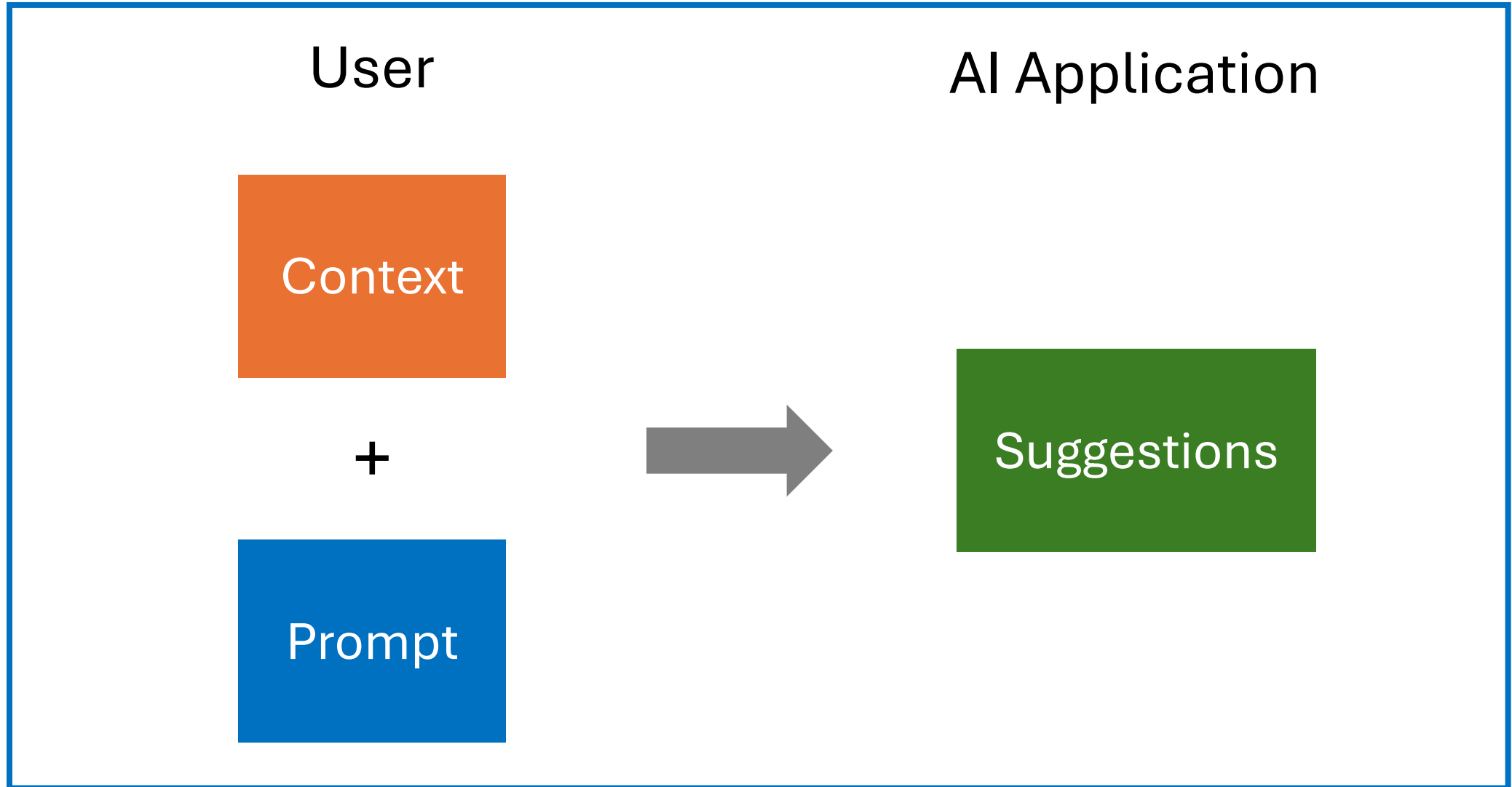
The perceived source is seen by recipients as:

- Authoritative
- Honest
- Having no vested interest
- Likeable
- Attractive

The message:

- Is attention grabbing
- Is simple
- Is memorable
- Is repeated, ideally from multiple sources
- Contains interesting or useful detail
- Conforms to what the recipients want to hear
- Elicits supporting thoughts and arguments in the minds of recipients
- Fits with or reinforces recipients' positive self identities
- Arouses concerns AND provides a way of reducing them
- Includes a call to immediate action
- Builds confidence
- Refers to credible authorities
- Creates a compelling narrative that fits with recipients' view about the world
- Makes use of cognitive biases (e.g., primacy effect, recency effect, confirmation bias)
- Addresses and rebuts any competing narratives

Can Generative AI help?



What to include in the context and prompt

BCTs

Communication
function

Communication
tone

Audience focus

The Prompt

I am responsible for creating messaging for a communications agency. I want to create a communication campaign to increase the number of people who sign up to donate blood.

I attach a document that contains: a list of BCTs that the campaign should deliver, communication functions that have been identified as relevant, the tone that should be used, and an analysis of the audience.

Give me 10 short suggestions for messages that will meet my brief, giving reasons

The Context

Behaviour Change Techniques (BCTs) to use:

- Raise awareness of the behaviour
- Prompt commitment to the behaviour
- Inform about the consequences of the behaviour

Audience features:

- Passive
- Uninformed

Communication functions to use:

- Apprise
- Show
- Inspire
- Reassure

Communication tone to use:

- Generous
- Friendly
- Empathetic



Claude.ai

1. "Did you know a single donation can save up to three lives? Your 45 minutes can change someone's entire future." *Reason: Raises awareness by providing specific impact information, apprises audience of the time commitment, and uses an empathetic tone by connecting to tangible outcomes.*
2. "Blood can't be manufactured. It comes from people like you. Sign up today—we'll guide you through every step." *Reason: Informs about consequences (medical necessity), reassures hesitant donors with support promise, and uses friendly language to overcome the uninformed/passive barriers.*



Claude.ai

1. "When you donate blood, you join a community of everyday heroes. Schedule your first appointment at [location/website]."
Reason: Inspires by framing donation as joining a positive community, prompts commitment with clear call-to-action, and uses generous tone that acknowledges donor value.
2. "Your blood type is someone's lifeline. Discover how your unique gift matters—book your donation today." *Reason: Shows the personal relevance of donation, apprises of individual impact, and addresses the uninformed audience characteristic with personalized framing.*



Key messages

Design for behaviour, not ‘buzz’

- Creative campaign design should always be linked to the path to impact
- The design should follow evidence-based principles in support of:
 - Attention
 - Comprehension
 - Acceptance
 - Recall
 - Engagement



To recap

Communicate to activate

Every behaviour change intervention should include a communications strategy.

Map the path to impact

Chart a clear causal path from what needs to change to what content and delivery are best suited to achieving this in the target audience

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